DISARMAMENT AND THE UNITED NATIONS: STRENGTHENING PEACE AND SECURITY THROUGH DISARMAMENT

The United Nations was founded on the belief that peace and security for all peoples would only be possible through disarmament. Article 26 of the United Nations Charter calls for “the establishment and maintenance of international peace and security with the least diversion for armaments of the world’s human and economic resources”. The UN Charter also provides for necessary commitments towards disarmament and arms control. Article 11 of the UN Charter declares “The General Assembly can consider the general principles of cooperation for the maintenance of international peace and security. These can include the principles governing disarmament, and the regulation of armaments”. Article 26 outlines the functions of the Security Council on matters relating to disarmament. It states that in order to promote the establishment of international peace and security, “the Security Council shall be responsible for formulating plans to be submitted to the members of the United Nations for the establishment of a system for the regulation of armaments”. Article 47 embodies provisions for the creation of a Military Staff Committee for advising and assisting the Security Council “on all questions relating to the Security Council’s requirements for the maintenance of international peace and security, the employment and command of forces placed at its disposal, the regulation of armaments, and possible disarmaments”.

The United Nations has worked for nuclear disarmament ever since its first resolution in 1946 entitled “The Establishment of a Commission to Deal with the Problems Raised by the Discovery of Atomic Energy”. The UN works for three types of nuclear disarmament:

- *General disarmament:* allows nations to keep minimum necessary police force.
- *Quantitative and qualitative disarmament:* involves overall reduction and abolition of only certain types of armaments.
- *Total disarmament:* the complete elimination of armaments.